

Cooper Canyon / Pawnee Mine I Provisional Backpack

April 11th and 12th 2009 (Easter Weekend)

Beauty and Iron Springs area

22.4 miles, 5200 ft of gain

Led by Matthew Hengst and Peter Doggett

I've been what is referred to as 'I' provisional with Sierra Club since late last year. That means I've fulfilled all the requirements for the 'I' rating (which would allow me to officially lead off trail and overnight) and just had to do the two provisional outings where I have an experienced co-leader there specifically to grade me on my performance and make sure I don't get too many people killed.

By the time I completed the last of the requirements there was already snow on the local mountains which meant certain trip ideas I had were not feasible.

Then Peter & Ignacia Doggett whom I had talked with several times about various ideas for trips mentioned an area out East of Temecula. It's a no man's land out in the desert punctuated by jeep and ATV trails and didn't fall under any of the usual National Forest / State Park / Bureau of Land Management designations.

So about a month previous to the trip Peter, Ingacia, and I ran out and scouted the area. The end result was the recently completed Easter weekend I provisional backpack.

There was a fair amount of interest from various folks when I socialized the trip and I ended up capping participation at an already sizable 15 people. After the usual last minute cancelations I had a respectable 11 person group (counting Peter and I.)

Meet Up and Move Out

We had an early start meeting at 7 am at a coffee shop in Temecula. Considering that's a 2 hour drive for some of us it made for an early morning. And of course I had once again flown back into town from my home away from home in Boise the previous evening.

The area around Temecula had received rain and thunderstorms Friday night and the forecast was threatening rain Saturday morning which just happened to be when I had us driving down a shoddy dirt road and climbing down a canyon. A narrow canyon in the desert during a rainstorm you say? What could go wrong?

I had alternate plans in case the weather became...interesting but as it turned out I needn't have worried. We had some low clouds and even a few sprinkles later in the day but never the torrential rain I had threatened my participants with.

After driving two miles down a dirt road we pulled off onto a flat area and piled out of our vehicles into the cool wind. The initial two miles took us further down the truck trail and over a few hills which served to rapidly warm us up. Once we reached where the road was crossed by a small stream trickling down from the local Twin Lakes the real fun started.



We hopped over the stream crossing and started down the southern branch of Cooper Canyon.



The terrain was a mix of rock, brush, and wet sand.



At times the canyon became impassible due to pooling water and I led us up the canyon wall to skirt around the problem sections. This was more exciting than usual considering we were wearing full packs

but everyone seemed to agree that the beauty of the canyon made up for the difficulty. (At least that's what they said out loud)



After about a mile and a half of this the canyon dropped us back on a jeep trail. From here it was a short slog up to the second main attraction, the remains of Pawnee Mine.

I noticed one big change from the previous trip I made to the area. Observe the collapsed building behind my group.



This is it from a month ago when I went inside to take pictures.



In addition there was the usual amount of trash and spent ammunition left by the jeep and ATV folks who come out to the area but we never saw anyone else that day.

We ate lunch at the cleared platform in the middle of the mine and then continued up the jeep trail to our camping area.





The camping area wasn't an officially designated campsite as they don't exist out there. It was however a natural site with large trees to provide shade and an intermittent stream running through the middle.

There were some indications others had stayed there. We found a few old fire rings but surprisingly little impact which made me think it had very few visitors.

We set up camp and grabbed our day packs for the next adventure, finding a local spring and touring a slot canyon and dry water fall further up the canyon from our camp.



It was a bit on the brushy side but absolutely off the beaten path.



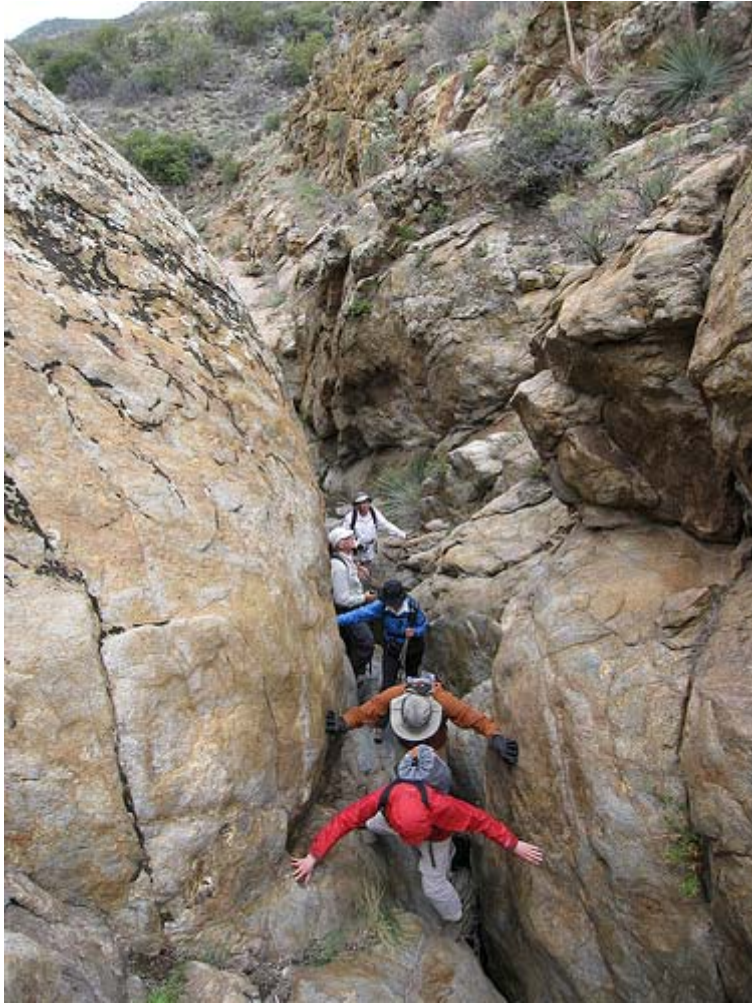


As we approached the spring we ran into a minor hitch. In addition to the fact ticks were out in force there was a large amount of newly sprouted poison oak. It was unavoidable we had to pass some of it much to everyone's joy.

The spring itself was completely surrounded by poison oak. As a result I changed our plans to pump water from there.



Once we passed the spring the poison oak disappeared and we were back to climbing through a red rock canyon. We made good time and soon came to the next attraction, a small slot canyon.



It didn't last for long but still made for some neat pictures and a quick climb up.



After that the canyon flattened out and after continuing a bit further I led us up the wall and back to the jeep trail that ran roughly parallel to the canyon. We used that to return to camp.

The stream back at camp was running slightly but had many stagnant areas and an odd smell to it. Because of that I decided to lead a short trek back down the hill to Cooper Canyon to pump water there. We had observed on the way in the flow was much stronger down there and we didn't have to worry about contact with poison oak.



This was probably the first time I've ever pumped from a road.

It was a 2-3 mile round trip and brought the total mileage for the day to about 9.4 miles.

One of the participants, David Sha, had remained behind when we went to pump and had dug out a hole in the stream. After setting up rocks it was clear of algae and had decent flow through it and was quite impressive all around.



We arrived back in camp ready for happy hour. The stoves came out and we gathered at some rocks near the entrance to camp.



Not content to bring the traditional bottle of wine poured into a Nalgene bottle Bill Simpson had brought a nearly 3 liter box wine. Add that to the bottle Robert & Markey had brought in a platypus and we had a well lubricated happy hour.



Between us we had canned oysters and crackers, salami and smoked Gouda cheese, fresh strawberries, pasta, brownies, cookies, chocolate, and of course wine. In addition to grazing Kim and I cooked a dehydrated meal which was good at warming us up.



It was during this time that I felt a few drops of rain which of course got me quite excited but alas, it wasn't to be. It did get colder as the sun started to go down and most people decided to walk / stumble for their tents a little after 7.

Due to the fact we were in a canyon there was a bit of a cold air flow which came down the slope. It actually got below freezing based on the frost waiting for us on our packs the next morning.

Kim and I were using my Tarp tent which I really like but one of its quirks is an opening near the ground at the front of the tent. Due to the way the ground was sloped we were set up with this opening pointed up the canyon. Can you say free air conditioning?

It was a bit chilly but other than a rather exuberant frog down by John Slagle's tent the night passed smoothly. Any headaches which may or may not have been experienced by participants or leaders the next morning no doubt came from the extreme altitude (somewhere around 3200 ft above sea level) and nothing to do with the large amount of wine drunk the previous night 😊

I turned out of bed early and fired up the stove to make some instant coffee. We had a 7:30 am start time for our day hike and by then the sun was on us and it warmed up significantly.



Above, Bill shows his appreciation for the warmth giving sun. I am constantly amazed by the amount of gear Bill can wear when it's only slightly chilly and still claim to be cold. I would be sweating like a pig.

Sunday was significantly warmer and with 3000 ft of gain waiting for us before we would reach our first peak we were soon all feeling quite warm.

We approached Beauty from the south up a prominent gully instead of the traditional use trail to the north east. This provided a nice workout and took us by a collapsed mine prospect.



After a fun little climb which was a great improvement from the initial route I scouted with Kim, a fact she reminded me of quite loudly for the rest of the day. We made the peak and signed in.

Descending we again had a much easier time than when it was just Kim and I. We had a strong group and it was still early enough I was able to take us up the second optional peak Iron Springs. This also happened to be my 75th HPS peak. Only 196 more to go...



By this time it was so hot we were all wishing for a breeze.

We returned to camp hot and tired and started to break camp. By now all our minds were turning towards the prospect of driving back to town and enjoying hot real food.

The hike out had not a small amount of gain to it but we made it through with a minimum of pain.

We did run into a group of off roaders at the mine driving a jeep, a truck, and two ATV's. They all looked at us like we were crazy as we walked by and exchanged greetings. We also found some newly discarded shotgun shells which explain the popping sounds we had heard of in the distance earlier that day.

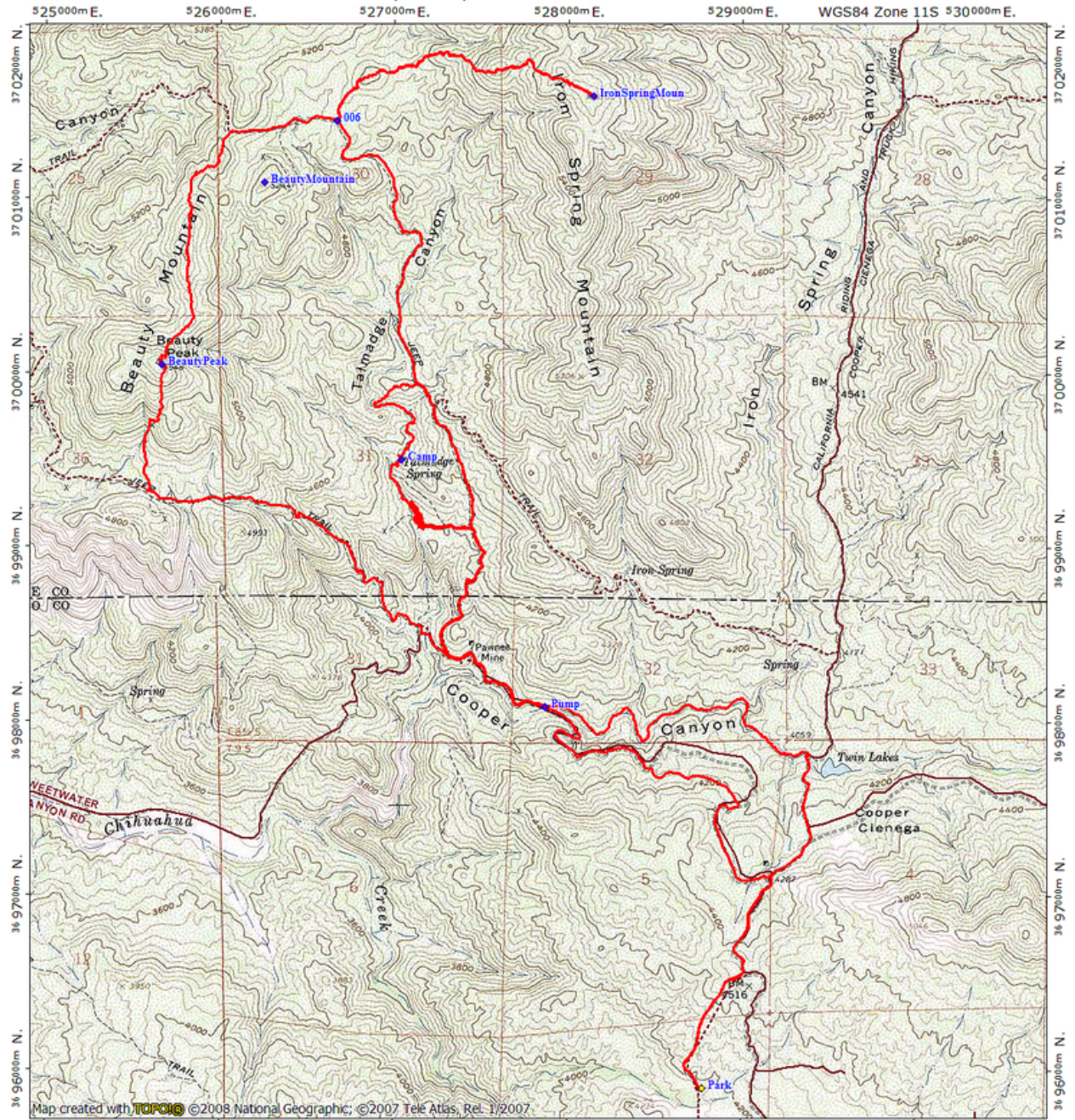
To our great relief our cars were right where we had left them and had not sprouted any new bullet holes while they waited for us. With the trip completed the majority of the group joined Kim and I back in Temecula to celebrate.



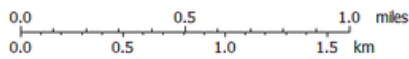
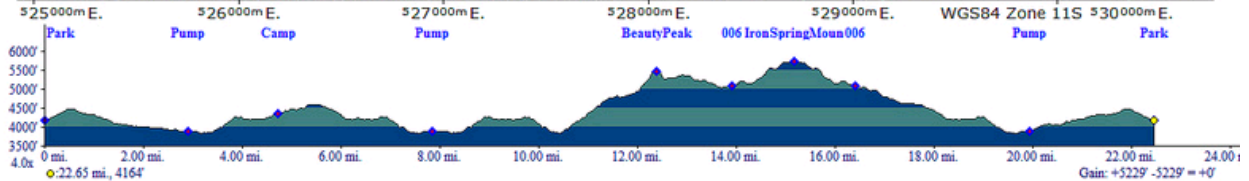
So once the paperwork for this trip is submitted and (hopefully) approved I now need to lead one more provisional outing before receiving my shiny new Sierra Club I Leader patch. I have a particular hike in mind that is just pending the snow clearing to a certain elevation before I put it on the schedule. I can then start officially on my technical rock and snow 'M' rating.

Original Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157616608364813/>

Cooper Canyon Pawnee Mine I Provisonal



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